- Judith Marshall offers a comprehensive analysis of the overall performance of the Brazilian mining company Vale and its impacts on workers and communities in Canada, Mozambique and Brazil itself. The behaviour of Vale exemplifies the worst tendencies of large mining companies, and contributes to global tensions by increasing the gap between rich and poor, along with exacerbating environmental degradation wherever it seeks minerals. A global civil society campaign is underway to link its victims' resistances.
- Both South Africa and Brazil suffered sub-imperial soccer temptations when it came to hosting the World Cup in 2010 and 2014, and Russia's turn is in 2018. Einar Braathen, Celina Sørbøe and Gilmar Mascarenhas discuss the allocation of resources for mega-events in a country, Brazil, whose institutional capacity to protect human rights and the environment was disappointingly fragile. In the context of neoliberal global competition among countries, the authors show how what they term 'cities of exception' are sold as 'global cities'. Exemplified by Rio de Janeiro, these cities seek to build coalitions between government and companies seeking 'opportunities for urban entrepreneurialism'. The FIFA 2014 World Cup and 2016 Olympics are creating a social backlash and the social sensibility that even the poorest people have a 'right to the city'.
- Moving to Eastern Europe, Ruslan Dzarasov locates Russia within the world system. It is, 'on the one hand, dependent on the core, but on the other aspires to control its own regional periphery in the area of the former USSR'. The contradictions can be seen in the way the parasitic fractions of the bourgeoisie pothole Russia's road back to regional dominance, in part through massive capital flight.
- Gonzalo Pozo adds more detail, especially in scoping out both the neoliberal nature of the Putin regime and its inter-imperial character. These features relate closely to the character of capital accumulation involving apparatchiks and the new bourgeoisie.

Finally, a group of shorter papers explore critical and contrarian positions on the BRICS within the world system. These contributions include analyses by William Robinson, Elmar Altvater, Sam Moyo and Paris Yeros, Susanne Soederberg, Ho-fung Hung, Achin Vanaik, Vijay Prashad, Immanuel Wallerstein, Niall Reddy and ourselves. While some – by Robinson, Vanaik, Prashad and Wallerstein – are overarching in scope, we also feel that specific moments and sectors are vital for understanding the internal contradictions. Altvater tackles environment, Moyo and Yeros consider super-exploitation, Soederberg looks at strategies of financial